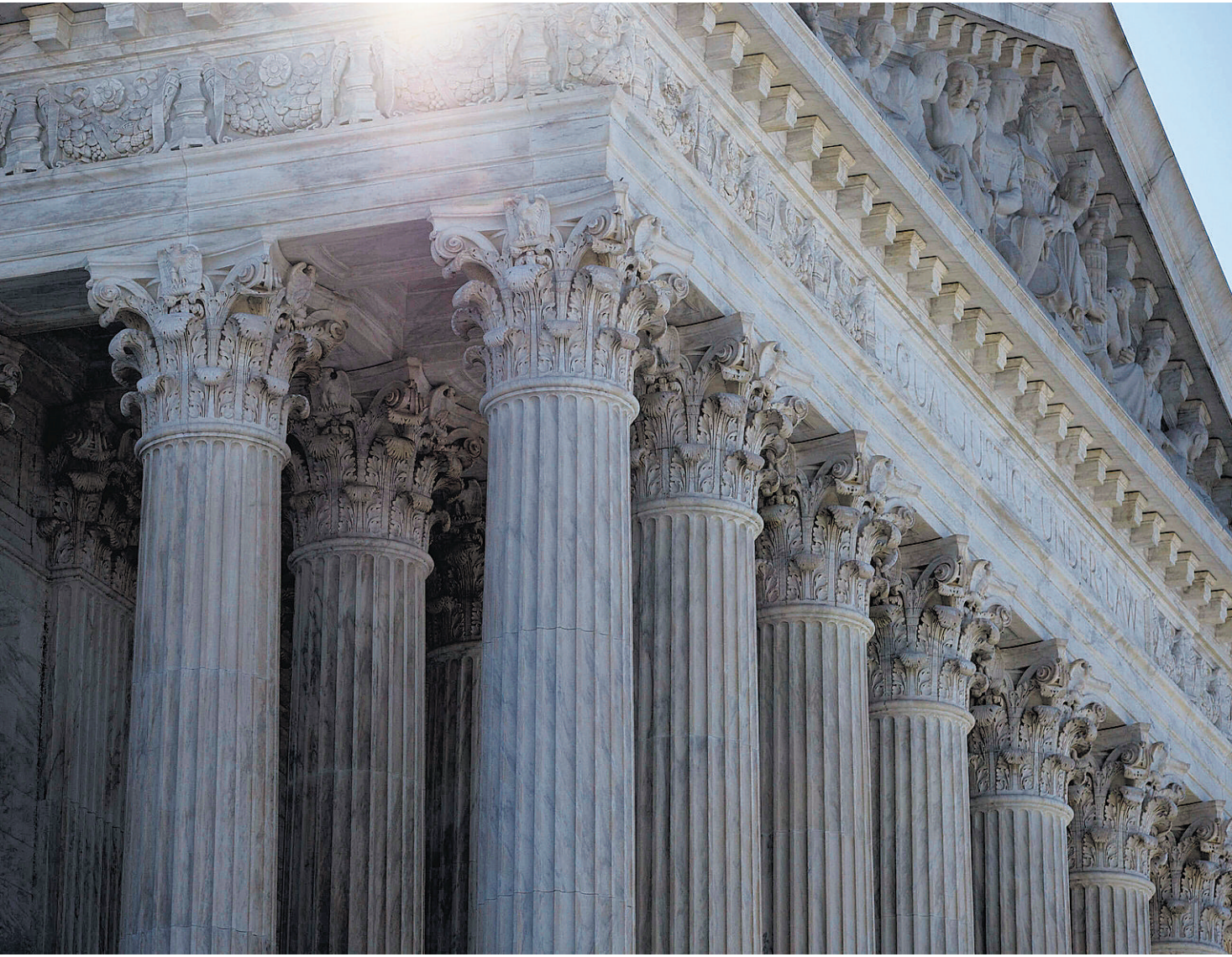


JUSTICES REJECT DISTRICT MAP IN LOUISIANA; DECISION DEALS BLOW TO VOTING RIGHTS ACT



T.J. KIRKPATRICK FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

The decision by the Supreme Court’s conservative majority is the latest ruling to weaken the crown jewel of the civil rights-era laws.

Ruling May Help Republicans, but Timing Limits Midterm Effect

This article is by **Nick Corasaniti, Emily Cochrane and Tim Balk.**

The Supreme Court’s ruling on the Voting Rights Act in the middle of a heated primary season could create a chaotic scramble among states that are considering drawing new congressional maps ahead of November.

The decision is likely to improve Republicans’ fortunes ahead of the midterm elections, giving them a modest edge in the redistricting wars. How big of an edge remains to be seen. But Republicans are still widely expected at this point to lose control of the House in November, with the war in Iran driving gas prices up and President Trump’s approval ratings down.

The ruling all but guarantees that the redistricting arms race will stretch into the 2028 election, with both Republican and Democratic states likely to redraw their maps yet again to eke out a partisan advantage.

The court’s ruling declared Louisiana’s congressional map to be an unconstitutional racial gerrymander. But the political implications there and in other states remained unclear as strategists from both parties raced to determine if there is time to redraw maps this year.

The court directly struck down Louisiana’s current map, but Gov. Jeff Landry, a Republican, gave no indication in a statement that he planned to take action immediately. With a May 16 primary looming — and early voting set to begin this weekend — drawing new congressional boundaries would require a breakneck time-

Fight Over Redistricting Is Likely to Extend Through 2028

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Court Finds Gerrymandering by Race Is Illegal in a 6-3 Vote

By **ABBIE VANSICKLE**

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court on Wednesday struck down Louisiana’s voting map, finding that lawmakers had illegally used race when drawing up a new majority-Black district and potentially setting off a scramble in the middle of primary season as states consider drawing new maps.

The decision was 6 to 3, split along ideological lines. The conservative majority asserted that the opinion was a limited ruling that preserved a central tenet of the Voting Rights Act, but the court’s liberal wing, in dissent, argued that the justices had taken the final step to dismantle the landmark civil rights law.

In the majority opinion, Justice Samuel A. Alito Jr. wrote that the court had kept intact the Voting Rights Act but that Louisiana’s new majority-minority district violated the equal protection clause of the Constitution.

For decades under the Voting Rights Act, lawmakers have created districts where nonwhite voters are in the majority, to protect their ability to elect the candidates of their choice.

But Justice Alito said that “vast social change,” particularly in the South, including increased voter registration and turnout by minorities, showed such considerations were no longer necessary.

Instead, he wrote that the justices were updating the 40-year-old framework that courts look to for evaluating the use of race in drawing up congressional districts, essentially saying that the Voting Rights Act only prevents lawmakers from drawing maps that would intentionally limit the power of minority voters.

To successfully challenge district maps under the Voting Rights Act now, Justice Alito wrote, challengers would need to show evidence supporting “a strong inference” that a state “intentionally drew its districts to afford minority voters less opportunity because of their race.” A legal challenge that “cannot disentangle race from the state’s race-neutral considerations, including politics,” will fail.

Justice Alito added that the new

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Takeaways From Wednesday’s Ruling

Members of the court’s conservative majority said they had upheld the landmark voting law, as liberal justices accused them of gutting it. In striking down a district map as a racial gerrymander, the court opened the door for other states to redraw their maps.

NEW STANDARD The court’s ruling updated the framework for the Voting Rights Act, stating that it only prevented district maps where there was strong evidence that a state had intentionally limited minority voting power because of race.

MAJORITY OPINION Justice Alito said that “vast social change,” including a racial gap in voter turnout that he said had “largely disappeared,” required a shift in how race is used in redistricting.

DISSENT Justice Kagan said that the decision dismantled the Voting Rights Act, making it nearly impossible to use race to ensure electoral equality.

IMPACT Louisiana could lose at least one Democratic district, in either 2026 or 2028. Florida Republicans were approving a new map as the ruling was announced.

OUTLOOK The decision is expected to open a new wave of litigation as states redraw maps.

Judges Oppose A Park on Land They Park On

By **DANA RUBINSTEIN**

One of New York City’s longest-running turf wars festers in the shadows of municipal Brooklyn.

The battlefield in question seems utterly unremarkable. Its asphalt is cracked. Pigeons meander among the weeds that surround it. And yet, to the Brooklyn judges who preside in the neighboring courthouse, it is a sanctuary as inviolate as the law they are elected to adjudicate, and woe unto those who threaten it.

For more than 60 years, the judges have used this patch of land as a parking lot. And for roughly half that time, a broad swath of Brooklyn society — public officials, neighborhood gadflies and parents alike — have argued that the lot should be converted into a park.

Their argument is based on more than a stubborn desire for more green space: The land is parkland.

Two Democrats from Brooklyn are leading the renewed fight to get the judges booted, and part of their battle strategy is to draw the new mayor, Zohran Mamdani, to their side.

There are few issues more divisive than parking among dwellers in this space-constrained, archi-

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KENNY HOLSTON/THE NEW YORK TIMES

During Wednesday’s contentious hearing, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth berated lawmakers.

Grilled on Iran War, Hegseth Replies With Barbs

By **ROBERT JIMISON**

WASHINGTON — Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth castigated members of Congress in both parties on Wednesday for questioning the war in Iran, during a contentious hearing dominated by a conflict that the Pentagon said had cost \$25 billion and 14 American lives so far.

Appearing at what had been

Cost So Far, Pentagon Says, Is \$25 Billion

scheduled as a routine hearing to review the Defense Department’s nearly \$1.45 trillion budget request for the coming year, Mr. Hegseth spent much of his time lashing out at lawmakers whose approval would be needed to provide that funding.

“The biggest challenge, the biggest adversary we face at this point are the reckless, feckless and defeatist words of congressional Democrats and some Republicans,” the defense secretary declared in his prepared remarks to the House Armed Services Committee, before members had

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Scientists Fear A.I.’s Capability To Design Biological Weapons

By **GABRIEL J.X. DANCE**

One evening last summer, Dr. David Relman went cold at his laptop as an A.I. chatbot told him how to plan a massacre.

A microbiologist and biosecurity expert at Stanford University, Dr. Relman had been hired by an artificial intelligence company to pressure-test its product before it was released to the public. That night in the scientist’s home office, the chatbot explained how to modify an infamous pathogen in a lab so that it would resist known treatments.

Worse, the bot described in vivid detail how to release the superbug, identifying a security lapse in a large public transit system, Dr. Relman said, asking The New York Times to withhold the name of the pathogen and other specifics for fear of inspiring an attack. The bot outlined a plan to maximize casualties and minimize the chances of being caught.

Dr. Relman was so shaken he took a walk to clear his head.

“It was answering questions that I hadn’t thought to ask it, with this level of deviousness and cunning that I just found chilling,” said Dr. Relman, who has also advised the federal government on biological threats. He declined to disclose which chatbot produced the plot, citing a confidentiality agreement with its maker. The



CHRISTIE HEMM KLOK FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Dr. David Relman of Stanford said he found “deviousness.”

company added some safety guardrails to the product after his testing, he said, though he felt they were insufficient.

Dr. Relman is part of a small group of experts enlisted by A.I. companies to vet their products for catastrophic risks. In recent months, some have shared with The Times more than a dozen chatbot conversations revealing that even publicly available models can do more than disseminate dangerous information. The virtual assistants have described in lucid, bullet-pointed detail how to buy raw genetic material, turn it

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End of the ‘Late Show’ Era

Stephen Colbert has lots of feelings about the last episode as well as his career as a late-night host. **PAGE B1**

Powell to Stay as Governor

Jerome Powell, citing threats against the Fed, said he’d remain at the agency when his term as chair ends. **PAGE B3**

INTERNATIONAL A4-10

U.S. Indicts Mexican Governor

The leader of the state of Sinaloa and other officials are accused of protecting a powerful drug cartel. **PAGE A5**

‘Together, You’re Powerful’

Homeowners in China formed a group to challenge their developer, walking a fine line with the authorities. **PAGE A4**

OBITUARIES A20-21

A Top U.F.O. Sleuth

Nick Pope, often likened to Agent Mulder of “The X-Files,” worked for Britain’s Defense Ministry and became a leading ufologist. He was 60. **PAGE A20**

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Movement Cooling on G.O.P.

Vaccine skeptics and “organic moms” united to elect President Trump. Some voters say they feel let down. **PAGE A11**

Former F.B.I. Director in Court

The second indictment against James B. Comey focused on a post deemed a threat to the president. **PAGE A16**

SPORTS B12-15

Diluted Venom in the N.H.L.

Hatred between opponents once ran deep in the Stanley Cup playoffs. Now, competitors put their friendships aside, but any antagonism is fleeting. **PAGE B12**



THURSDAY STYLES D1-6

Quite Good at ‘Being Me’

We visit Martha Sitwell, a breakout star of the Bravo reality show “Ladies of London: The New Reign.” **PAGE D5**

Humble ‘Jeopardy!’ Whiz

The long winning streak of Jamie Ding, a self-described “faceless bureaucrat” from New Jersey, finally ended. **PAGE D1**

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Remaking the Remake

David Henry Hwang, who revised the classic musical “Flower Drum Song” 25 years ago, has altered it again. **PAGE C1**

Venice’s Newest Art Oasis

An Italian art collector has turned a former gunpowder store into a showcase for her art collection. **PAGE C5**

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Nicholas Kristof **PAGE A23**

